

More of the SAME

Khanduri is the first victim of the BJP's poll debacle but successor Nishank may not be the cure for its ills



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Among the many liabilities that the tiny hill state of Uttarakhand inherited from its parent state of Uttar Pradesh from which it was bifurcated in 2000 is political instability. In the last nine years, the state has already seen five chief ministers. Be it the Congress or BJP, factional feuds within the parties and over-ambitious local leaders with myopic vision have caused frequent political turmoil. The elevation of Ramesh Pokhriyal Nishank, the state's seniormost cabinet minister, as the state's new chief minister is a fallout of the same.

In 2007, Uttarakhand had voted out the Narain Dutt Tewari-led Congress government and opted for the BJP in the hope that the ouster of the faction-ridden Congress regime would bring some stability and subsequent development and progress to the state. Their hopes have been belied. The BJP Government headed by B.C. Khanduri, a retired major-gen-

THE CAMARADERIE BETWEEN NISHANK (CENTRE) AND KHANDURI IS NOT EXPECTED TO LAST

eral and former Union minister, too remained engulfed in intra-party wrangling and party feuds. His appointment by the BJP high command came despite stiff opposition from the state unit. Once in office, he was held hostage by rival groups, one of them headed by former chief minister Bhagat Singh Koshiyari who threatened to resign from Rajya Sabha recently amidst the high drama that was played out in the BJP. In August last year, he provoked 27 MLAs to

Nishank has a clean image but takes over at a time when the state is virtually in ruins. He's running against time.

flash their resignation letters before the party high command in Delhi. They were pacified by the BJP leadership which promised them that Khanduri's ouster will be considered if the BJP failed to perform well in the general elections of 2009. That's what exactly happened last month when Uttarakhand became the only state where the BJP, despite being the ruling party, was decimated by the Congress and faulted to win even one of the five seats at stake in the state. That fuelled the anti-Khanduri flames, leading finally to his departure.

The BJP legislature party has elected Nishank as their new leader to become the fifth chief minister of the state. Nishank has been a genuine claimant to the post from the day the state was created. But the BJP first made the ailing Nityanand Swami chief minister. Widely regarded as incompetent, Swami failed to deliver and was succeeded by Koshiyari who had never contested any election, including that of gram pradhan, in his more than 40-year-old political career. Koshiyari fought for his first assembly seat as chief minister but under his dispensation the BJP was defeated by the Congress, which was again ousted by the party in 2007.

Nishank heads the state at a time when the tiny state is almost in ruins—government machinery is at a standstill, financial mismanagement abounds and no new schemes are being implemented to empower the people. Nishank, a cabinet minister in undivided Uttar Pradesh, is widely perceived to be a leader who has stayed away from controversies and has no greed for power. Age is on his side too; he is young compared to his predecessors.

"My priority would be to expedite development of the state. I have been at the forefront of the Uttarakhand Banao movement, so I am well aware of the expectations and needs of the people. I promise to make my efforts hundred per cent," Nishank told INDIA TODAY after being formally chosen as chief minister. The sense of déjà vu could not be missed.

by Subhash Mishra